We have to combine — A conversation is all you need

Using small language models as conversational routers for agentic software engineering

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Contents

Status and scope **3**

Abstract **4**

1 Motivation and research questions **5**

2 Prior art and the conversational-routing question **7**
2.1 Review scope and novelty verdict 7
2.2 Established components and optional personal capabilities 8
2.3 From query routing to an acting small agent 9
2.4 EdgeWise: the closest software-engineering precedent 10
2.5 Conversation is a treatment to measure, not a novelty shortcut . . . 11
2.6 Personal memory is established, and its benefit is not automatic . . 12
2.7 Learning collaboration without reinventing an RL stack 13
2.8 What a credible extension would establish 13

3 System and implementation **15**
3.1 Four connected capabilities 16
3.2 Reusing Codex 16
3.3 Memory and context controls 17

4 Experimental design **18**
4.1 Conditions and estimands 18
4.2 Engineering pilot 19
4.3 Confirmatory software-engineering study 19
4.4 Ablations needed to explain an effect 20
4.5 Learning collaboration without reinventing distillation 21
4.6 Persistent many-to-many extension 21

5 Measurement and economic analysis **23**
5.1 What counts as saving money 23
5.2 Published price and accuracy context 24

6 Live engineering-pilot results **25**
6.1 Execution and independent grading 25
6.2 Forced bidirectional mechanism check 26
6.3 What the pilot cannot estimate 26

7 Industry-standard benchmark: a 500-task routing replay **28**
7.1 Data and interpretation 28
7.2 Routing method and leakage controls 28
7.3 Primary result: savings with an unacceptable quality loss 29
7.4 Portfolio comparison: a strong cheap single model is essential . . . 30

7.5 Statistical and economic limits 31

8 Discussion and limits **33**

9 Reproducibility and next execution **35**

10 Conclusion **37**

References **38**

Status and scope

This is a research paper and master's-thesis core, with a reproducible engineering pilot, a completed 500-task SWE-bench Verified routing replay, and a prospective confirmatory conversation protocol. Its central contribution is an empirical replication and conversational-routing extension, **not a claim to have invented small agents that consult larger models**. The broader earlier thesis contains supporting reviews of open-model portfolios, prices, distillation, browser benchmarks and deployment. Those materials do not change the active protocol in this paper.

The empirical section distinguishes live model trials from software tests and unexecuted experiments. An opaque hosted model called Luna is a practical controller proxy, not evidence of a particular parameter count, open weights or local-device feasibility. Sol is the pilot expert. User consent covers these Codex agent experiments. The separately authorized one-80-GB-GPU Runpod budget of US$100 has not been spent on this work.

Author, university, supervisor and submission declarations remain for the author to complete. No institutional approval or model-training result is implied by this manuscript. Historical estimated inference savings are reported separately from unmeasured conversation benefits, current bills and subscription usage.

Abstract

Can a small acting model reduce the total cost of agentic software engineering by conversing with larger experts while retaining nearly the same task success? The proposed mechanism is continuing, bounded dialogue: the controller works locally, selects context, asks for assistance, answers clarification questions, challenges proposals and integrates a verified result. This is broader than initial model selection and more specific than an unconstrained agent swarm. Learned routing, selective cloud delegation and multi-agent interaction already have substantial prior art; this work is a replication and controlled extension.

We implement a thin experiment layer over Codex with persistent controller and expert threads, bounded exchanges, independent grading and explicit missing-cost handling. A live historical-bug pilot compares a single Luna agent, a single Sol agent, task-only prompt routing and optional conversational assistance on four issues from two repositories. Functional regression success is respectively 3/4, 4/4, 4/4 and 3/4. All optional controllers chose zero expert calls, so this matrix does not estimate the value of an actual conversation. A separate required two-round clarification-and-integration check passes its 30 regression tests. Strict artifact-policy outcomes are reported separately because several workers added assertions inside existing test files.

An additional experiment fits cross-validated pre-task routers on 5,000 published agent outcomes: ten models on all 500 SWE-bench Verified tasks using mini-SWE-agent 2.0.0. The primary half-budget router achieves 64.2% success at US$0.2551 per task, versus GPT-5.2's 72.8% at US$0.4736. Estimated inference cost falls 46.1%, but the 8.6-point quality loss fails the three-point tolerance. A ten-model portfolio operating point reaches 76.2% at US$0.1154; inexpensive MiniMax-M2.5 alone reaches 75.8% at US$0.0733. The latter comparison prevents attributing the benefits of model choice to routing. These historical outcome replays are not new model inference or live conversations.

The confirmatory protocol compares conversation with single-model execution, pre-call routing and one-way assistance under matched information and resource budgets. The proposed gate combines a three-percentage-point quality tolerance with lower measured total cost; a 25% saving is the practical target. Personal memory, learned collaboration skills and multi-agent communication are optional ablations and extensions. The pilot exposes no complete billing ledger and is not powered for noninferiority. It therefore establishes execution feasibility, not conversational cost savings, local-model capability or learning improvement. The standard-benchmark replay supplies a reproducible negative primary result and identifies a stronger low-cost standalone control for the next experiment.

Keywords: conversational routing; small language models; software-engineering agents; bidirectional collaboration; cost–quality tradeoffs; replication.

Chapter 1

Motivation and research questions

The immediate research goal is a small acting controller that combines its own work with outside expertise through conversation. A personal agent that remains responsible to its user is one motivating application. A user should be able to inspect and change what the agent remembers, retain control of project goals and decide which information external services receive. The compact model need not solve every problem independently. Its useful role can include understanding the task, doing inexpensive work, asking a precise question, evaluating the answer and incorporating a tested change.

These responsibilities are more demanding than choosing a model from an initial prompt. They also create overhead and new failure modes. The controller may misdiagnose a problem, omit crucial context, accept an incorrect suggestion or spend more on coordination than direct expert execution. Personal memory may be stale, irrelevant or less useful than a generic project guide. Learning can reinforce a mistaken delegation habit. These possibilities motivate controlled experiments rather than an assumption that a multi-model system is better.

The research questions are:

1. Can an acting small controller with bounded expert dialogue lower total cost while retaining accepted software-task success relative to a single expert given the same information, tools and resource envelope?
2. Does consultation after observing the repository and test feedback add value beyond a task-only router selecting one model before work begins?
3. Does persistent bidirectional dialogue add value beyond one-way assistance or reset expert calls under the same total budget? Which effects come from selective context sharing, verification or optional personal memory?
4. Can development experience improve the controller's decisions about when to ask, what to send and how to recover on later, disjoint tasks?
5. At which measured total-cost operating points is the resulting system useful, and which privacy, latency and local-access tradeoffs remain?

The core hypothesis is materially lower total cost with only a prespecified small loss of task performance. Conversation may also improve performance, but that is a separate claim. The first live pilot addresses feasibility and a restricted version of the first two questions. The remaining questions require the registered ablations and longitudinal data. A null finding is informative: if the same-context expert

remains better or the controller cannot exploit assistance, the proposed complexity is not justified in that setting.

The project's guiding sentiment is "Believe in me who believes in you." It is a motivation for persistent investigation, not a substitute for falsifiable claims.

Chapter 2

Prior art and the conversational-routing question

2.1 Review scope and novelty verdict

The broad architecture has already been demonstrated. A small model that acts, decides when to consult larger models, incorporates their responses, and learns a cost-sensitive collaboration policy is not a new invention. Most directly, **EdgeWise** evaluates a local small-model solver with selective cloud delegation on software-engineering and terminal tasks, and trains its delegation decisions with reinforcement learning (Shi et al. 2026). **Router-R1** previously learned multi-round model invocation and aggregation with a three-billion-parameter controller (Zhang, Feng, and You 2025). **Uno-Orchestra** jointly learns decomposition and worker selection across a heterogeneous model pool (Cui et al. 2026). Calling the proposed system the first thinking router, the first small agent helped by large models, or the first agent to learn when to delegate would therefore be incorrect.

The primary question for *We have to combine — A conversation is all you need: Using Small LMs as Conversational Routers for Agentic Software Engineering* is empirical: **can a small acting agent use bounded, bidirectional conversations with larger experts to reduce total cost while keeping verified task quality within a prespecified acceptable loss, and does conversation add value over one-way delegation?** Expert clarification questions, the small agent's challenges, revisions and subsequent verification form the treatment of interest. This is a replication and extension of selective collaboration, with a controlled communication ablation and fuller cost accounting. Editable personal memory and persistent user goals are optional extensions, rather than prerequisites for the main claim. The contribution rests on reproducible evidence and controls; neither conversation nor its combination with a small controller should be presented as a first invention. The targeted review cannot establish universal priority.

The search combined title/abstract searches on arXiv for personal agents, delegation, small/large-model collaboration and developer skills with backward references and official repositories. Versioned primary texts were inspected for methods, evaluation conditions and limitations; the accompanying source register records URLs, retrieval dates, hashes and failed accesses. This is a targeted review through 26 October 2026, not a PRISMA systematic review or

an exhaustive patent search. Several closest studies are recent preprints. Their reported results are evidence to examine and reproduce, not measurements performed by this project.

2.2 Established components and optional personal capabilities

The earlier four-capability personal-agent design remains a useful map of related work. The main experiment isolates conversational expert assistance; memory and experience learning can be added as separate interventions after this comparison is established.

Proposed capability	Closest established work	What still needs a controlled test here
Editable goals, project history and preferences	MemGPT, Letta, A-MEM; personalized coding skills; personal-agent memory benchmarks	Whether the correct person's memory improves executable work beyond generic procedural guidance, and whether revisions are respected
Small agent acts and selectively asks experts	Router-R1; EdgeWise; Uno-Orchestra	Whether delegation remains useful after equalizing personal context, tools, budgets and expert access
Tests, critique, constraint checking and integration	ReAct-style tool loops, Reflexion, coding harnesses; EdgeWise task-solving loop	Whether explicit acceptance and recovery procedures prevent harmful expert overrides without excessive cost
Learns collaboration from experience	Router-R1 RL, EdgeWise delegation RL, ReMA, Memento, Agent Lightning	Whether learning improves unseen personal/project tasks, and how much training or experience cost must be amortized

The position paper *Small Language Models are the Future of Agentic AI* already argues for heterogeneous systems and describes an LLM-to-SLM conversion procedure (Belcak et al. 2025). This supports the motivation to democratize agent capability, but a position statement and replacement case studies do not establish the proposed system's measured advantage.

The meaningful unit of evaluation is the whole agent system. A controller can be a smaller model without being a local model; an agent can preserve memory without updating weights; and a model can be trained to delegate without learning useful personal preferences. These are separate interventions. In particular, a Codex Luna/Astra/Sol pilot can test an orchestration mechanism using existing agents, but model names and service tiers do not establish parameter counts, desktop feasibility or open-weight deployability.

2.3 From query routing to an acting small agent

RouteLLM provides a strong reusable example of preference-based selection between weak and strong models; it is a useful one-shot routing baseline (Ong et al. 2025). It does not exhaust the relevant prior art. Router-R1 treats routing as a sequential process: its controller interleaves internal deliberation with model calls and incorporates responses into an evolving context. The inspected version trains Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct and Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct with PPO in veRL, allows at most four routing steps, and uses 14,000 training questions split between Natural Questions and HotpotQA. Evaluation covers seven general and multi-hop QA datasets, with 500 sampled items per dataset except the smaller Bamboogle set. Its six-worker pool spans several model families and sizes (Zhang, Feng, and You 2025, secs 3–4).

Router-R1 is particularly close to the proposed "personal model as the brain." The controller is itself a solver and synthesizer; the workers contribute complementary information. Its reward includes format correctness, exact-match task outcome and a cost term. However, the main experiments set the cost coefficient to zero; separate experiments vary it and report the resulting quality–cost trade-off. The cost construction uses candidate output tokens and a model-dependent price function. It should not be read as a measurement of every infrastructure and training expense. Its QA setting also does not establish repository repair, executable verification, persistent personal memory or user-goal management. Reusing the released implementation is more appropriate than inventing another generic multi-round router. The inspected official repository has an Apache-2.0 license and links released models and data.

MasRouter adds a different relevant dimension: it selects collaboration mode, agent roles and language models using a cascaded controller, rather than selecting only the model for an isolated query (Yue et al. 2025). Its main pool includes GPT-4o-mini, Claude 3.5 Haiku, Gemini 1.5 Flash and Llama 3.1 70B, with DeepSeek-V3 used for inductive evaluation. Its five datasets include HumanEval and MBPP. These are useful coding tasks, but they do not constitute a persistent personalized repository agent. Its reported cost reductions compare specific pools and system configurations; they cannot be transferred to a new model generation or converted into a universal savings rate. The official code is Apache-2.0.

Uno-Orchestra makes the novelty boundary still narrower. It uses a Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct orchestrator, selectively decomposes tasks and chooses admissible model–primitive combinations, and trains from worker-grounded trajectories. Its main pool contains nine commercial workers; its 13-benchmark suite includes code, SWE-bench Verified, terminal tasks and tool use (Cui et al. 2026, secs 4–6 and Appendix A). Consequently, neither heterogeneous expert selection nor learned decomposition is a new contribution here. Its macro-average and dollars-per-query aggregate over different task domains under its own rollout harness. They are not a same-task comparison with the proposed study. Moreover, the paper's linked author repository returned HTTP 404 during this review. A separately discoverable repository with the same title was not established as an author-verified replacement. This limits immediate reproducibility; it does not negate the paper as prior art.

2.4 EdgeWise: the closest software-engineering precedent

EdgeWise directly studies the proposed small-first operating pattern. The local SLM continuously interacts with the environment and delegates selected steps to a stronger cloud model. It compares an external-judge policy with self-delegation learned inside the small model, investigates which steps benefit from assistance, and evaluates five ways of supplying context to the cloud model (Shi et al. 2026, sec. 3). Full history, the previous step, recent history, history without the small model's analysis, and selected relevant steps are already explicit ablations. Selective context transfer therefore cannot itself be presented as an unexplored idea.

The self-delegation method uses SFT to teach the action format, then RL to improve task solving and delegation. Delegated expert tokens are excluded from the small policy's loss. Its trajectory reward combines correctness with a successful-trajectory bonus that decreases with the number of cloud calls; the paper explicitly distinguishes this regularizer from directly optimizing monetary cost. A critic supplies additional credit on delegation tokens. This is closely related to the requested learning of when local work is sufficient and when an expert is necessary. Critic agreement is a training signal, however, not an independent proof that a particular call caused task success.

The reported training scale also matters. Section 4.1 uses Qwen3.5-9B, SWE-smith tasks, 2,000 SFT examples, and RL with Kimi-K3 on **40 A100 80 GB GPUs for 175 steps**, batch size eight and 16 rollouts per example. The current authorization of one 80 GB GPU and US$100 does not fund a faithful reproduction of this training configuration. It can support a smaller feasibility experiment if its scope and stopping rule are explicit. A prompted Codex delegation experiment is an architecture probe, not a reproduction of EdgeWise's trained checkpoint.

The main evaluation uses Terminus2 with an 80-turn cap on Terminal-Bench 2.1 and SWE-ReBench-03. Table 1 compares Qwen3.5-9B plus either GPT-5.5 at xhigh reasoning effort or Claude Opus 4.8 through Bedrock against large-model-only and several routing baselines. For the GPT-5.5 SWE-ReBench comparison, reported pass@1 changes from **56.36% to 58.18%**, and pass@3 from **63.64% to 66.36%**; the corresponding reported API-cost reductions are **51.22% and 52.68%**. The Opus comparison illustrates the trade-off more clearly: pass@1 falls from **60.00% to 57.27%**, while the reported API cost falls by **62.68%**. These are within-paper comparisons on the stated benchmark configuration, not evidence that every quality target is preserved. The inspected text does not establish a noninferiority margin and confidence interval for that claim.

Crucially, EdgeWise counts cloud input/output-token API cost and includes the external judge where used, but **excludes local SLM computation** from its main cost comparison (Shi et al. 2026, sec. 4.2). Training, local hardware and idle capacity are not recovered by quoting its headline savings. The inspected text also does not make the task denominator of its dollar column sufficiently explicit for this review to convert those values into a new per-task price. The present thesis should report measured dollars per assigned task and per resolved task from its own event ledger, including failures, retries and local costs, and separately report amortized training cost. EdgeWise's reported lower API bill remains useful evidence under its stated accounting boundary.

The practical deployment uses a DGX Spark with vLLM 0.19.1 and BF16, rather

than an arbitrary consumer laptop. Appendix G.2 describes approximately 78.7 GB of reserved unified memory, including a substantial KV-cache allocation. It demonstrates one edge workstation configuration; it does not establish that the exact deployment is freely runnable on every desktop. The project page linked from the paper was blocked by the current environment's proxy, and searches did not verify an official code/checkpoint release or its license. The project should therefore reuse the method as cited prior art while tracking implementation availability, rather than claiming that a released EdgeWise package has been integrated.

2.5 Conversation is a treatment to measure, not a novelty shortcut

Router-R1 already incorporates expert responses across multiple routing rounds, Uno-Orchestra learns sequential orchestration, and EdgeWise alternates local and cloud contributions within a continuing task (Zhang, Feng, and You 2025; Cui et al. 2026; Shi et al. 2026). These precedents make conversational assistance plausible, but they do not by themselves isolate the benefit of a persistent expert clarification channel. The inspected methods establish multi-round invocation and response integration; this review did not establish a matched experiment that disables only expert-initiated clarification and challenge–revision exchanges while retaining the same models, task state, tools and inference budget. That bounded observation identifies a useful ablation, not proof that such an experiment has never been performed or that dialogue is new.

Operationally, the conversational condition lets the expert ask for missing evidence, lets the small agent answer or challenge a proposal, and lets the same expert revise its response before the small agent verifies and integrates it. The comparison should include a single delegated response and a repeated-call control with equivalent opportunities to spend compute. Otherwise, any improvement may reflect more tokens, attempts or preserved context rather than reciprocal communication. Log message direction, clarification requests, supplied evidence, revision events and accepted artifacts. Neither a long transcript nor a higher message count establishes useful collaboration; quality and total cost remain the outcomes.

EdgeWise's cloud-API savings provide prior evidence for the economic hypothesis under its accounting boundary. They do not establish that additional dialogue reduces total expense, because context retransmission, model switching, local inference, verification and unsuccessful conversations can consume the savings. The central test therefore combines a prespecified quality noninferiority criterion with measured total cost per assigned and resolved task. The title's "a conversation is all you need" expresses the proposed coordination interface; working tools, an execution harness and independent acceptance checks remain necessary parts of the system.

2.6 Personal memory is established, and its benefit is not automatic

MemGPT's management of external memory and Letta's persistent state already support long-lived agents (Packer et al. 2024; Letta contributors 2026). A-MEM studies dynamically linked and evolving memories (Xu et al. 2025). These systems motivate editable application memory instead of retraining for every changed fact. They do not imply that remembering more will improve every decision. Facts, preferences, active goals and reusable procedures should have distinct provenance and update rules; temporary task instructions should not silently become permanent user preferences.

A directly relevant coding study, *Do Personalized Skills Help Coding Agents?*, uses Codex with GPT-5.5 to generate skills, execute coding tasks, simulate the developer and score completion (Huang, Du, and Lan 2026). After reconstructability filtering, it retains 206 sessions from 13 developers, dividing them into 164 evolution sessions and 42 test sessions per split. It repeats the experiment with five split seeds and caps each replay at six developer-agent turns. The comparison includes no skill, the correct developer's skill, a random other developer's skill, and a generic skill pooled across evolution histories. The evaluation is therefore unusually close to the proposed use of Codex and personal histories.

Table 1 reports mean completion scores of **65.02** without a skill, **65.99** with personalized skills, **65.94** with another developer's skill and **68.80** with generic skills, on its 100-point LLM-judged rubric. These are not executable test pass rates. The simulator and scorer share the GPT-5.5 family with the coding agent, so correlated judgments and replay realism remain relevant limitations. Nevertheless, the result directly challenges the assumption that personalization must help: the study finds small, inconsistent personal gains and more consistent generic-skill gains. A correct-user versus no-memory comparison alone would fail to isolate useful personalization. If personalization is added, that extension should include generic and shuffled-user memory controls, use executable acceptance checks where possible, and evaluate changed or conflicting preferences rather than only static recall.

MemPABench provides another recent caution (Li et al. 2026). Its on-policy environment uses four grounded simulated users, 14 interaction preferences and 99 sessions over four months, with event-driven preference changes. It measures decisions to clarify, confirm or act, rather than only recalling a personal fact. The reported limited gains and inappropriate generalization of file-based preferences motivate measuring delivered behavior separately from retrieved memory. This is adjacent interaction-preference evidence, not software-engineering accuracy evidence.

The nanoMuse report independently establishes that an open personal agent with readable memory files, user-chosen models, cross-device continuity and persistent operation is also an existing product direction (Liu, Liu, and Zhang 2026). Its GitHub repository identifies GPL-3.0, while the paper labels size and cost as estimates and describes evaluation components still on its roadmap. It is relevant architectural prior art, not proof of a measured cost–quality advantage over frontier coding agents.

2.7 Learning collaboration without reinventing an RL stack

"Learning from experience" covers several different treatments. Reflexion updates textual episodic feedback without changing model weights (Shinn et al. 2023). Memento combines planning, execution and memory-based adaptation; its case-selection policy and episodic memory are not equivalent to fine-tuning the underlying LLM (Zhou et al. 2025). The inspected official Memento implementation is MIT-licensed and describes a planner–executor loop with MCP tools. These are practical baselines for the question of whether new verified experience improves later collaboration before attempting parameter updates.

ReMA already learns collaboration between a high-level strategic agent and a lower-level reasoning agent using multi-agent RL (Wan et al. 2025). Its primary results concern reasoning and judging tasks rather than a user-owned persistent coding system. GPTSwarm already optimizes agent prompts and graph connectivity (Zhuge et al. 2024). Thus, many-to-many communication, learned role allocation and evolving collaboration graphs are established research directions. A swarm extension should examine explicit questions about stability, useful specialization and cross-agent credit assignment; observing different role names or more messages is not evidence of emergent competence.

For later weight training, Agent Lightning v1.0 is a reusable MIT-licensed framework specifically intended to retain real harness tools, context and control flow during RL (He et al. 2026). Its primary text reports a mini-SWE-agent pipeline using SWE-smith-derived data and Qwen3.5-9B. The framework addresses request/response capture, sample construction, token alignment, advantage calculation and backend scheduling. Those are substantial reasons to reuse it rather than build a custom RL engine. The current repository and license were inspected at a pinned commit; this review did not run its GPU training pipeline.

In the proposed study, executable test rewards, AI-generated critiques and monetary penalties should remain identifiable components. A test-derived correctness signal is not RLAIF merely because an AI produced the patch. An AI critic's preferred delegation decision may be wrong and should be assessed against controlled counterfactual branches on development tasks when affordable. In a later learning extension, keep the expert frozen while first training the controller policy, mask expert-produced tokens from that policy's objective where the selected algorithm requires it, and compare with an equally experienced single-model control. Otherwise, extra training or extra expert inference can be mistaken for a special benefit of collaboration.

2.8 What a credible extension would establish

DecisionBench is an instructive evaluation precedent (Gao et al. 2026). It fixes a peer pool, delegation interface and information channels, and measures process outcomes in addition to final quality. Its headline study covers GAIA, tau-bench and BFCL multi-turn, with 11 models and five conditions; its released code also contains an appendix-only SWE-Bench Pro adapter. Across 23,375 task rows, its reported changes in routing fidelity do not translate into a clear mean quality improvement. Selecting a seemingly appropriate expert is therefore insufficient: the full system must actually solve more tasks or solve them with

less measured expense. The official Hugging Face code/data repositories were reachable, although this review did not establish an explicit software license for redistribution.

The defensible experiment keeps the same software tasks, initial repository states, task context, tools and acceptance checks across small-only, large-only, task-router, one-way delegation and bidirectional small-controller–expert conditions. A matched large-controller condition tests whether the smaller controller contributes beyond simply adding an extra reasoning stage. Budget-matched repeated calls separate the effect of conversation from additional inference. Record local attempts, help requests, clarification and revision events, context bytes/tokens disclosed, expert artifacts accepted or rejected, verification failures, recovery steps, latency and full resource use. If personal memory is added, compare correct-user, generic and shuffled-user memory independently of architecture. An optional history-conditioned policy can later be compared with its frozen counterpart on a new time-ordered evaluation block; it should not repeatedly learn from the final test panel.

This design supports a precise contribution statement: **a reproducible evaluation of whether small agents acting as conversational routers can reduce total software-engineering task cost with minimal quality loss, and whether bidirectional clarification, challenge and revision improve on one-way delegation under comparable budgets.** It extends established selective-collaboration research rather than claiming a first architecture. A negative result is informative if one-way delegation, an existing router or a single larger model already achieves the same frontier. Personalization and learning remain separately testable extensions. A successful small Codex pilot can justify larger runs; it cannot establish open-model local deployment, RL improvement, long-term learning or a statistically stable dollar-cost frontier without the corresponding measurements.

Chapter 3

System and implementation

The central mechanism is a continuing conversation between an acting small controller and one or more experts. The four personal-agent capabilities below are useful extensions, not four mandatory components of the hypothesis. The minimal system can omit personal memory entirely and still test conversational routing. Expert replies can ask for missing information or challenge the current plan. The controller can supply evidence, reject a suggestion or request a revision; both threads persist across the exchange. A bounded conversation is therefore distinguished from a single request followed by an accepted answer.

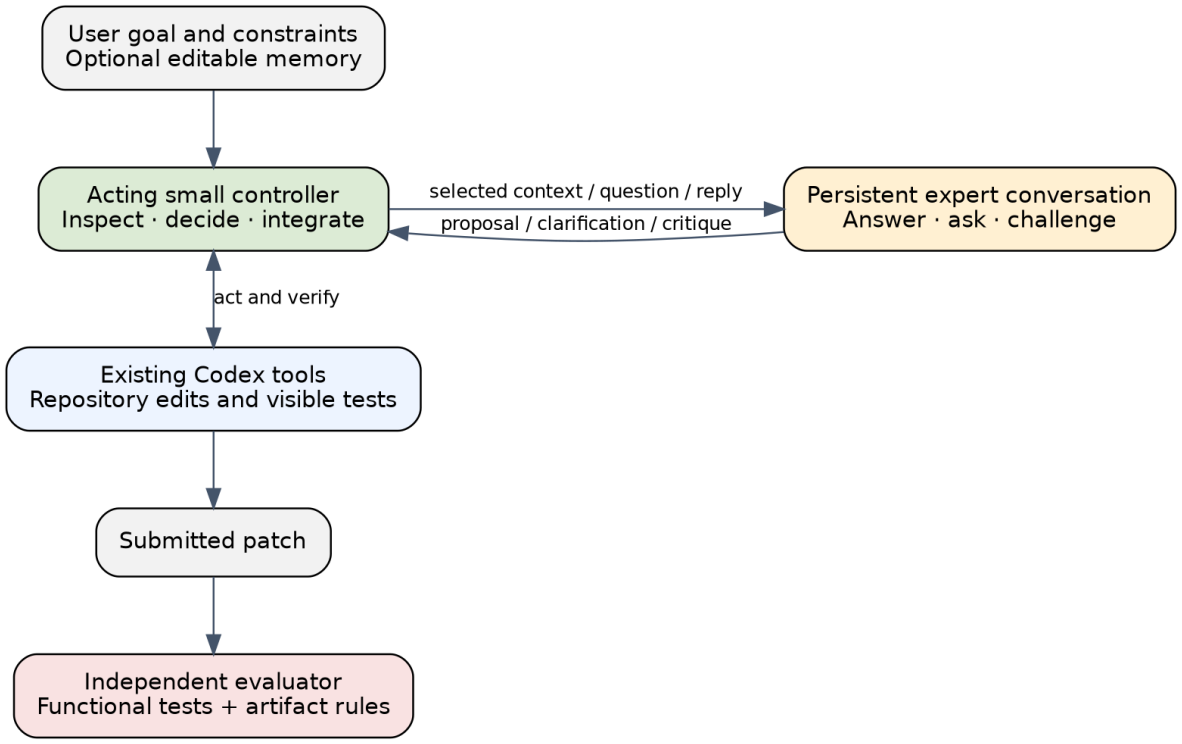


Figure 3.1: An acting controller and a persistent expert exchange questions, evidence and proposals. Independent grading stays outside both agent workspaces.

3.1 Four connected capabilities

The system state at decision time is $x_t = (g, m_t, h_t, w_t, b_t)$: the current goal and mandatory constraints g, editable memory m_t, observable interaction history h_t, workspace state w_t and remaining resource budget b_t. The controller's available actions are local work, expert consultation, verification, integration, memory proposal and task completion. This is a partially observed sequential decision problem; an initial-prompt router observes only a restricted state before any local work.

Personal understanding. Memory contains explicit goals, project decisions, preferences and relevant history with identifiers and provenance. Facts remain ordinary local data that can be corrected or deleted. Session state, repository files, a learned adapter and a model's KV cache are different objects. Changing a deadline must not require fine-tuning a model. Procedural skills may eventually be represented by a versioned skill file or compatible adapter, but neither is treated as the authoritative store of user facts.

Expert collaboration. The controller first has permission to inspect and work on the repository. It may ask a bounded expert a question or request a plan, diagnosis, patch proposal or critique. A request contains the task contract, selected relevant context, the unresolved question and the expected form of response. The expert does not automatically receive the user's entire memory or the controller's full history. Asking and acting are both eligible choices; a personal agent that succeeds without calling an expert is not a failed treatment.

Verification and integration. The controller retains responsibility for the submitted patch. It can run visible tests, inspect diffs, reject a suggestion or ask for clarification. The independent evaluator separately decides whether the final artifact passes the registered task tests. Visible tests help the agent, whereas hidden grading tests measure it. Passing a tool call or receiving a confident expert answer does not establish that the task is solved.

Learning from experience. Observable records connect the state available at a decision to the request, response, verification and outcome. Useful targets include recognizing an unproductive local search, selecting sufficient context, question formulation, challenging a flawed proposal and recovering from failed integration. An ultimately successful trajectory does not make every earlier decision optimal. Learning therefore uses development-only comparisons and counterfactual rollouts when feasible, instead of labelling all actions in a successful run as good.

3.2 Reusing Codex

The experiment uses Codex's existing model/tool execution rather than a new coding-agent loop. The repository adds a small experimental wrapper in `src/ttgl/personal.py`: task and condition manifests, expert request boundaries, continuation of the controller thread, event recording and resource limits. Single-model and personal conditions use the same coding interface. A separate module, `src/ttgl/pilot.py`, checks the assigned trial matrix and produces paired descriptive summaries without inventing missing usage.

The standalone adapter invokes `codex exec --json` and interprets documented thread, completion and usage events. The expert begins in a separate read-only

session; subsequent exchanges resume that expert thread. Its structured response is an answer, a request for context or a challenge. The controller continues its own thread to inspect evidence, answer questions and integrate the response. The wrapper caps turns, expert calls and elapsed time. A Codex turn can contain multiple internal model/tool interactions, so a turn cap is not falsely reported as an exact cap on billable inference requests. Timeout handling terminates the wrapper's process group and preserves a failure disposition.

In this managed session, the installed standalone CLI identifies itself as version 0.163.0 but cannot initialize its in-process app server because the required state location is read-only. We do not bypass that restriction. The live pilot therefore uses the available Codex collaboration interface with fresh, explicitly selected models. The reusable CLI adapter is tested with an injected deterministic backend; those tests verify control flow, not model quality. The two execution paths are recorded as distinct backends.

The collaboration interface does not expose a reliable itemized token invoice to this experiment. It also shares a filesystem among agents. Workspaces are separate copies, and instructions prohibit reading other trials, evaluator files or external solutions, but this is a soft boundary rather than an OS-level confidentiality guarantee. Stronger held-out evaluations require separate containers or machines with an evaluator outside the agent's mount namespace.

3.3 Memory and context controls

All conditions receive the same relevant personal-memory snapshot for a given task. The expert-only baseline is not deprived of user preferences. In the personal condition, the controller decides which part of that snapshot to send to an expert. In a future minimal-disclosure experiment, synthetic canary facts and explicitly irrelevant preferences permit measuring unnecessary transmission without using real private user data. That experiment reports disclosure alongside task success; withholding essential context can reduce quality.

Memory changes have separate categories. Factual edits are user-controlled state updates. Proposed procedural lessons cite their development evidence and can be accepted, rejected or reverted. A factual-memory-only control receives the same updated facts without learned skills, while a generic-skill control tests whether personalization adds anything over broadly useful instructions. Deletion and stale-fact correction are evaluated explicitly in longitudinal tasks. A system that remembers more but cannot forget is not considered a successful personal-memory implementation.

MCP can expose tools and state services, and A2A can provide remote agent task interfaces. The communication review in the supporting thesis examines their versioned capabilities. They do not by themselves learn who should communicate or prove that a returned artifact is correct. Slack is an optional human-visible transport, not a requirement for the experiment, and no external Slack messages are sent by this study.

Chapter 4

Experimental design

4.1 Conditions and estimands

The unit of analysis is an assigned repository issue, not an individual model call. Every registered issue is assigned to every primary condition. Each run starts from a clean copy of the same buggy revision and receives the same issue description, relevant memory, editable source boundaries and visible tools. The primary conditions are:

Condition	Behavior	What it estimates
S: single controller	Luna acts and verifies without model assistance	Controller's independent capability
L: single expert	Sol acts and verifies throughout	Same-context strong-agent reference
R: pre-call routing	A task-only Luna decision selects S or L, then a fresh selected agent acts	Initial allocation without adaptive collaboration
C: conversational routing	Luna acts, exchanges up to two expert turns with Sol, then verifies and integrates	Added effect of adaptive expert conversation

R is a prompt-based routing baseline. It is **not** a reproduction of RouteLLM, Router-R1, MasRouter or EdgeWise. Those methods require their own eligible model pairs, learned parameters, training data and runtime assumptions. Reusing a router calibrated for a different pair without validation would not establish its performance on Luna and Sol. Native implementations, where available and licensed, enter a larger study as separately named arms.

The C-versus-L contrast tests the complete product architecture. C-versus-S tests whether access to help is useful. C-versus-R tests adaptive consultation against initial selection. None alone identifies the value of personalization, because all primary conditions share the same memory. That value requires the memory and skill ablations below. Sol may be replaced by Astra or an open-weight expert only as a separately versioned comparison; outcomes are not pooled under the vague label "large model."

4.2 Engineering pilot

The pilot uses genuine historical Python bugs from the public BugsInPy corpus (BugsInPy contributors 2026). A deterministic feasibility screen checks candidate bugs in the registered order before any candidate-agent outcomes are observed. A usable task must have a buggy revision that fails its regression check and an official fixed revision that passes it under the recorded environment. Every compatibility exclusion is retained. If a harness adaptation is necessary, its exact change and rationale are recorded; the pilot does not inherit the official BugsInPy leaderboard's meaning merely by using its bugs.

Task descriptions can be derived from the behavior exercised by an upstream regression test when a self-contained issue statement is unavailable. This is recorded as a derived task prompt, not presented as an untouched benchmark instance. Reference patches and grading fixtures are kept outside the worker copy, with the shared-filesystem limitation stated above. Small historical fixes provide a useful execution check but may have a ceiling effect and may already be present in model training data.

The task list, source revisions, prompts, constraints, baseline checks, grading commands and analysis design are frozen before the live trials. Model settings, fresh-session identifiers, selected routes, expert requests and submitted patches are archived. The same task cannot be silently rerun until it passes. An infrastructure retry is separately identified and preserves the first attempt. Completed and failed assignments remain in the denominator. The feasibility screen is independent of the models being compared.

In the personal condition, expert responses contain only the context provided by the controller and their resulting proposal. The pilot limits assistance to the registered number of consultations. A controller may choose zero calls. Baselines receive the same task time envelope; the personal condition's budget includes its expert waiting and integration time. These are wall-time controls, not claims of equal token consumption. Model reasoning-effort settings are recorded, and the unobserved internal compute differences remain a limitation.

The pilot is developmental. Its issues, outputs and human observations are excluded from later training/calibration/test claims that require unseen examples. It establishes that the architecture can be executed and independently graded, and identifies measurement or orchestration failures. It cannot prove noninferiority, cost superiority, architectural novelty, long-horizon learning or a benefit for open-weight local models.

4.3 Confirmatory software-engineering study

The proposed primary evaluation uses a pinned release of SWE-bench Verified, with the official evaluator and recorded image digests (Jimenez et al. 2024; SWE-bench Team 2024). Development data come from disjoint issues and bug clusters; a repository-unseen analysis additionally excludes all development data from its registered repositories. Public benchmark exposure and opaque model training data remain contamination risks, so a prospective private or newly released issue replication is desirable.

For each task, accepted success is functional resolution **and** satisfaction of feasible

prespecified mandatory constraints. Resolution and constraint adherence are also reported separately. A requirement such as preserving a public API or avoiding new runtime dependencies must be machine-checkable or independently reviewed under a frozen rubric. Requirements are screened for consistency with the task before outcomes are observed. Hidden constraints that the agent was never told are not introduced after submission.

The proposed primary gate is C-versus-L quality noninferiority with a margin of three absolute percentage points, followed by superiority in mean total cost per assigned task. A 25% reduction is the proposed practical target; both its point estimate and uncertainty must be reported. These thresholds are prospective design choices and are not fitted to pilot outcomes. The margin is an explicit engineering tolerance, not a universal customer preference. It must be approved in the protocol freeze before held-out execution. A failed noninferiority test is inconclusive about equivalence. A claim of improved quality is a separate, multiplicity-controlled test, not an alternative success criterion chosen after seeing results.

Three recorded repetitions per task are planned for the fully funded study. Repeated seeds remain nested within tasks. Paired task-weighted effects and repository-clustered uncertainty are reported with a conditional-on-repositories sensitivity analysis. Sample-size planning uses development-only discordance, variance and cost observations. The full matrix is not assumed to fit the US$100 Runpod pilot allocation. A dated resource plan must include failed runs, container evaluation, model loading, artifact storage and cleanup before that study starts.

4.4 Ablations needed to explain an effect

The essential conversational ablation is **one-way assistance versus continuing two-way dialogue**. In the former, an expert returns a bounded proposal and does not ask clarification questions; in the latter it can ask, challenge and revise in the same thread. Match the expert pool, permitted context and total budget, and report actual turns rather than forcing a conversation on every easy task. A third version resets expert state between requests, separating retained conversation from simply spending more inference. This contrast is a testable extension, not a universal claim of priority over all prior multi-agent work.

Memory, cooperation and learning are different interventions. The follow-up matrix therefore includes no personal memory, correct matched personal memory, generic project guidance and shuffled-user guidance. Shuffled material uses synthetic profiles and is an experimental control, never a product behavior. The generic-skill baseline is especially important because prior personalization research reports that pooled skills can outperform personalized skills.

Within the cooperative condition, compare task-only expert selection with small-first consultation, full permitted context with selected context, and expert-only completion with controller integration. Verification ablations can remove additional controller critique while preserving the independent final grader. They cannot give one condition access to hidden tests. A manager-only condition tests coordination without local work; it is not the flagship personal-agent treatment.

Expert competence and extra inference are potential confounds. Use the same expert backend across conditions, retain router/manager overhead, and include

a large-controller-with-the-same-expert option when studying controller size. An equal-total-budget single-expert condition tests whether extra thinking by one model explains an apparent multi-agent advantage. Expanded expert portfolios are added after the dyadic comparison, with pool size and expertise held fixed within each contrast.

4.5 Learning collaboration without reinventing distillation

Classical sequence or logit distillation is background and an optional component, not the central experiment. The learning question concerns the personal agent's collaboration policy. Start with frozen weights and versioned procedural skills; compare no update, factual-memory-only update, generic skill update and personalized skill update. The development curriculum presents tasks in a fixed order and evaluates later disjoint tasks at frozen checkpoints. Evaluation feedback never modifies a policy during its final test.

For a weight-learning replication, use a maintained agent-training framework such as Agent Lightning rather than building a new RL trainer. Pin its release, instrumentation boundary and training data. The initial compatible open model and runtime must be validated independently; the hosted Luna pilot provides no access to Luna weights and does not train that model. A Runpod key alone cannot make hosted-model fine-tuning available.

A transparent reward decomposition is $r = Y_{\text{accepted}} - \lambda C - \mu V - \nu B$, where C is measured resource cost, V counts registered constraint violations and B penalizes budget violations. Coefficients are selected on development data and frozen. If only call counts are available, the objective is labelled a call-count penalty, not a monetary-cost objective. Task tests provide executable feedback; this is not automatically RLAIF. AI feedback requires a declared judge, rubric, blind human audit and reward-hacking checks. It may supplement task tests, not replace independent functional evaluation by assertion.

Credit assignment should compare continuing locally, asking with different context packages and choosing different experts from the *same predecision state*. Those extra rollouts incur acquisition cost. Future expert replies and hidden grader results cannot enter the features available to an earlier delegation decision. Evaluate held-out accepted success, unnecessary and missed delegations, context sufficiency, recovery success and full amortized cost. A falling expert-call count is valuable only when quality and constraints remain satisfied. No monotonic learning curve is assumed.

4.6 Persistent many-to-many extension

A swarm adds persistent worker memories, task ownership and communication topology to the decision problem. It is a separate extension, since improved group performance can otherwise be attributed to more models or more inference. Begin with fixed roles and durable task identifiers. Compare a star centered on the personal agent with a bounded peer graph and a learned communication graph, under equal total token, tool and time caps and the same expert pool.

Measure accepted team output, duplicate work, lost handoffs, stale-memory errors, message volume, context disclosure and recovery after an agent restart.

Role specialization must improve held-out performance and transfer across goals to count as useful emergence. A visually interesting conversation pattern is not evidence. Learning can use centralized training with decentralized execution, but rewards and credit attribution must be specified. This extension remains prospective and does not delay or inflate the claims of the core dyadic study.

Chapter 5

Measurement and economic analysis

5.1 What counts as saving money

The main hypothesis concerns the whole system, not merely the number of calls to a strong model. For assigned task i, define

$$C_i = C_{S,i} + C_{L,i} + C_{\text{router},i} + C_{\text{tools},i} + C_{\text{handoff},i} + C_{\text{retry},i}.$$

For API services, each component uses observed billable input, cached input, output and separately billed reasoning/tool categories at a dated endpoint price. For rented inference, include occupied instance time, startup, model loading, storage and cleanup. Local hardware has both a marginal-cost scenario and a fully allocated scenario including energy and amortization. Training and experience-acquisition costs are separately amortized over a stated task horizon. Do not add a token-price estimate to an instance bill when they represent the same inference expense.

Cost per assigned task is $\sum_i C_i/N$. Cost per resolved task is $\sum_i C_i / \sum_i Y_i$, so failed attempts remain in the numerator. If there are no successes, the latter ratio is undefined, not zero. The proposed cost ratio is $\bar{C}_C/\bar{C}_L$ after the quality gate. Savings are $1-\bar{C}_C/\bar{C}_L$. Unknown cost components prevent a full-cost claim. Counting only paid cloud tokens supports a narrower API-bill claim, which must be labelled accordingly.

Conversation can save expensive model work but add repeated context, latency and cache misses. A resumed conversation preserves logical state, not a guaranteed physical KV cache. Switching models or adapters can require prompt reprocessing. Record actual cache usage where the provider exposes it, and measure cold versus warm service conditions in open-model deployment. LoRA adapters are tied to compatible base models; arbitrary cross-model adapter sharing is not assumed.

Report an empirical quality–cost frontier at development-selected operating points. Changing the price sensitivity, maximum expert turns or escalation threshold creates different policies. The final test cannot choose the best threshold retrospectively. Decision quality includes false local confidence, unnecessary consultations, unresolved requests, useful expert replies rejected and harmful

replies accepted. A correlation between expert calls and failure is not causal evidence that experts hurt: difficult tasks may trigger those calls.

5.2 Published price and accuracy context

The supporting source audit contains an independently reconciled historical SWE-bench Verified comparison using mini-SWE-agent 2.0.0, 500 assigned issues per submission, dated 17 February 2026 (SWE-bench contributors 2026). These are third-party reported inference costs, not invoices, full infrastructure expenses or current-model prices. They must not be mixed with this four-task pilot to rank the architectures.

Historical model	Resolution	Reported USD / assigned task	Derived USD / resolved task
MiniMax M2.5 high, open weights	75.8%	0.0733	0.0967
Claude Opus 4.6, closed	75.6%	0.5515	0.7295
GLM 5 high, open weights	72.8%	0.5344	0.7341
GPT-5.2 high, closed	72.8%	0.4736	0.6505
Claude Sonnet 4.5 high, closed	71.4%	0.6579	0.9214
Kimi K2.5 high, open weights	70.8%	0.1466	0.2070

The exact source revision, 3,000 per-instance cost records and arithmetic are registered in the supporting `task-economics-sources.json`, `task-price-checks.json` and `task-price-comparisons.csv`. The price per resolved task includes spending on unsuccessful assignments. Matching a named scaffold and benchmark improves comparability but does not erase differences in model settings, serving or submission procedures. These historical figures establish that open-weight and closed systems can occupy different cost–quality points; they do not identify the present best model.

The 25 October 2026 model catalog separately records recent Qwen, DeepSeek, GLM, Kimi and closed-provider releases, licenses and price-source limitations. For example, a current compact Qwen checkpoint is a candidate for an eventual open-model controller replication, whereas very large sparse DeepSeek models do not become deployable on one 80-GB GPU merely because their active parameter count is small. Current inference frameworks and model compatibility require a real preflight. Model selection is frozen per experiment, rather than silently substituting the newest release mid-run.

Chapter 6

Live engineering-pilot results

6.1 Execution and independent grading

The pilot completed **16 assigned model runs**: four conditions on four bugs from two repositories. Three bugs are from tqdm and one from PySnooper; some concern related Boolean/initialization behavior. These are four assignments, not four independent repository clusters. All eight pre-model evaluator controls passed: each buggy version failed and each official fixed version passed its selected regression module. A later integrity check confirmed the recorded source and test hashes before grading the submissions.

All workers used fresh conversations, explicitly requested medium reasoning effort and the same pinned Python test environment. The primary matrix used Luna and Sol through Codex's collaboration interface. No Runpod GPU was created. No model was trained. The frozen protocol hash is recorded in every grading report, and the individual submissions, test output, JUnit records and analysis inputs are archived. Reported model self-checks are not substituted for the independent grading below.

Condition	Functional regression success	Accepted under frozen artifact rule	Expert consultations
Single Luna	3/4	3/4	0
Single Sol	4/4	4/4	Not applicable: Sol is the sole worker
Task-only prompt router	4/4	2/4	Router selected Luna for every task
Optional conversational Luna controller	3/4	0/4	0

The two columns answer different questions. The frozen grader rejects **any change to an existing test file**, including adding assertions, while allowing new test files. All four conversational workers and two routed workers edited an original test file. Those submissions therefore fail the artifact policy even where the independent regression tests pass. The policy is stricter than the ordinary meaning of "do not weaken tests," and the personal-worker prompt said "preserve existing tests; adding tests allowed." This wording leaves room for additive changes. The resulting acceptance difference is a protocol and

instruction-adherence issue, not evidence that all those patches are incorrect. The rule was not changed after outcomes, and both endpoints are preserved.

There were two functional failures in the matrix. The Luna-only PySnooper patch applied representation again to a custom formatter's returned string, adding unwanted quotes; the independent custom-representation tests caught it. The optional-conversation tqdm Boolean patch returned false when neither iterable nor total was supplied, while the registered regression requires a TypeError. Its added local test instead endorsed the altered behavior. These cases show why an agent's passing self-tests cannot replace independent acceptance tests.

Every task-only routing decision selected Luna. Its 4/4 functional score versus the separate Luna-only 3/4 run is not evidence that the router identified a better backend: it chose the same backend on every issue. These are different stochastic sessions with slightly different role instructions. Likewise, the optional conversational controllers all chose zero consultations, so their outcomes do not estimate the value of an actual dialogue. No held-out labels were used to revise or rerun those submissions.

6.2 Forced bidirectional mechanism check

Because no optional controller exercised the expert channel, a separate engineering check required a two-turn expert exchange on the original PySnooper base. This was planned after observing the lack of consultations and is not a fifth performance condition or an independent held-out issue.

Luna inspected the code and sent selected context to a fresh Sol expert. The expert was instructed to ask one clarification question before proposing a solution. It asked whether custom representation should apply to watched and expanded values or only ordinary frame locals. Luna investigated the rendering paths, answered that the task concerned ordinary locals and asked the same expert thread for a proposal. Sol supplied a design preserving the existing representation-shortening and error-handling path. Luna implemented and tested the patch. The independent selected module passed **30/30 tests**, with no artifact-policy violation. The visible dialogue is archived verbatim as reported by the controller.

The first collector invocation used a relative JUnit output path; pytest passed but the collector looked in the wrong directory and recorded zero tests. The original record is retained. Regrading the unchanged patch with an absolute output path recovered the 30 passing checks. This was an evaluator-output-path correction, not another model attempt. The two reports have the same patch hash.

This establishes that live clarification, reply, proposal and integration can be performed through the existing harness. It does not show that the mandatory conversation was necessary, cheaper, naturally selected or superior to a single-model solution.

6.3 What the pilot cannot estimate

The interface exposed neither a complete token ledger nor billed dollar costs. These fields are stored as null, including cost per assigned and resolved task. Root-observed start/completion timestamps are delayed batch envelopes containing

scheduling and orchestration; they are not reported as comparable model latency. No quantitative savings claim can be drawn from these measurements.

Four historical bugs, two repositories, one attempt per condition, soft filesystem isolation, potentially contaminated tasks, task-order effects and opaque hosted model versions prevent a frontier or statistical noninferiority claim. There is no trained existing-router comparison, no open-weight local model result, no learned communication policy and no evidence of longitudinal improvement. The matrix is useful evidence about feasibility and failure modes, and the dialogue check validates a mechanism. The principal economic hypothesis remains untested.

Chapter 7

Industry-standard benchmark: a 500-task routing replay

7.1 Data and interpretation

We executed a new routing analysis on **all 500 SWE-bench Verified tasks**, using the ten complete public submissions dated 17 February 2026 in the official SWE-bench experiments repository (SWE-bench maintainers and submission authors 2026). Each submission uses mini-SWE-agent 2.0.0 and supplies per-instance resolution, estimated inference cost and API-call counts. This gives 5,000 recorded model–task outcomes, not 5,000 independent tasks. Costs and accuracies reconcile to every submission's published metadata. The source revision is `40f164d5b8f1d249bf95a6df8b74b577fd8e519d`; task text comes from the official task repository at `3d07b464b7b311a0cbfb5ed5b2d8a3b96f84a33d`. Canonical task identifiers join the records. We did not independently establish that this later task-text snapshot is byte-identical to every original model prompt used in February.

These are **new router fits and outcome replays of previously executed agents**. We did not rerun those ten models, infer unseen patches, or observe their current prices. Their historical outcomes are held fixed while we select among them. This experiment measures the cost–quality opportunities and limits of pre-task selection in this portfolio. It does not identify the effect of bidirectional communication, distillation, local inference or Codex subscription consumption. Same-harness-version comparisons still differ in model-specific settings, reasoning effort, service behavior and potentially execution conditions.

The protocol and model grid were frozen before fitting. Aggregate source accuracies and prices had already been inspected during dataset selection, so this is exploratory secondary analysis, **not prospective preregistration**. All scripts, source hashes, folds, numerical task records and results are archived under `experiments/swe-replay-001` and `results/swe-replay-001`.

7.2 Routing method and leakage controls

Five task folds use seed 1729. For each held-out fold, training uses only the other 400 tasks. Word unigram/bigram TF–IDF, logarithmic issue length and a repository

indicator feed per-model logistic success predictors and ridge regressors of log-transformed task cost. The vectorizer and transformations are fit only on that fold's training data. Test patches, reference solutions, trajectories, actual held-out cost and held-out outcomes are excluded from decision features. An instance identifier is used only for deterministic ties.

The primary policy allocates GPT-5.2 to half the tasks and GPT-5-mini to the remainder, ranked by predicted success gain per predicted incremental dollar. Allocation takes place within each held-out fold. A global ranking over cross-fitted predictions could otherwise let a task's label influence competing tasks' scores through their training folds. The within-fold quota avoids that indirect selection path. This is a batch allocation policy, not a validated online arrival-by-arrival budget controller.

Fixed single-model policies, random allocation, length and predicted-gain baselines, a declared allocation grid, and a ten-model expected-utility grid are also evaluated. Utility is predicted success minus a fixed coefficient times predicted task cost. A separate subgroup uses models tagged open by the source metadata; that tag is not our license audit or evidence that the models run on a desktop. A label-and-cost-informed oracle is deliberately marked nondeployable. Its apparent performance is an upper bound conditional on these recorded attempts, never a usable router result.

7.3 Primary result: savings with an unacceptable quality loss

Policy	Resolved	Success	Estimated inference USD/task	USD/resolved task	Saving vs GPT-5.2
GPT-5-mini alone	281/500	56.2%	0.0472	0.0840	90.0%
GPT-5.2 alone	364/500	72.8%	0.4736	0.6505	Reference
Expected random 50% mixture	322.5 expected	64.5%	0.2604	0.4037	45.0%
Primary learned 50% router	321/500	64.2%	0.2551	0.3974	46.1%

The primary router's estimated inference total is **US$127.5667**, compared with **US$236.7835** for the GPT-5.2 reference on the same 500 tasks. Its 46.1% saving comes with an **8.6 percentage-point** resolution loss. The paired task-bootstrap 95% interval for the quality difference is approximately **−11.6 to −5.6 points**; the estimated saving interval is **40.8% to 51.4%**. Repository-cluster sensitivity also fails the quality gate. The proposed three-point noninferiority margin is not supported. This is a negative result for the primary joint target, despite a substantial cost reduction.

The learned router also does not demonstrate a useful accuracy improvement over the expected random half-mixture: its paired difference is −0.3 points with a task-bootstrap 95% interval from −2.4 to +1.9 points. The corresponding cost ratio is 0.980, with interval 0.884 to 1.076. A cheaper policy is not useful evidence for the central hypothesis when its success falls outside the declared tolerance. The paired outcomes include 262 issues both models solve, 19 solved only by GPT-5-mini, 102 only by GPT-5.2, and 117 by neither. The existence of complementary successes does not imply that pre-task features can reliably identify them.

The primary router's break-even additional overhead is about US$0.2184 per task; only US$0.1000 per task remains if a 25% inference-plus-overhead saving is the target. Adding a hypothetical US$0.05 overhead per task lowers its saving to 35.6%, without repairing the observed quality loss. These overhead values are sensitivity assumptions, not measured router or environment bills.

7.4 Portfolio comparison: a strong cheap single model is essential

All rows below use all 500 recorded assignments. The costs include failed attempts. They are historical upstream estimates, not current provider quotes.

Published model	Success	Estimated inference USD/task	USD/resolved task
GPT-5-mini	56.2%	0.0472	0.0840
GPT-5.2, high	72.8%	0.4736	0.6505
DeepSeek-V3.2, high	70.0%	0.4478	0.6398
Kimi-K2.5, high	70.8%	0.1466	0.2070
MiniMax-M2.5, high	75.8%	0.0733	0.0967
GLM-5, high	72.8%	0.5344	0.7341
Gemini-3-Flash, high	75.8%	0.3560	0.4696
Claude-Haiku-4.5, high	66.6%	0.3309	0.4969
Claude-Sonnet-4.5, high	71.4%	0.6579	0.9214
Claude-Opus-4.6	75.6%	0.5515	0.7295

MiniMax-M2.5 alone resolves **379/500** at **US$0.0733 per assigned task**. Its historical estimated inference cost is 84.5% below the GPT-5.2 reference, with a three-point higher observed success rate. This is evidence about **model choice in the archived comparison**, not a routing effect and not a local-small- model result. Model size cannot be inferred from price or the word "mini".

For illustration within the prespecified exploratory grid, the ten-model utility policy at coefficient 0.25 resolves **381/500 (76.2%)** at **US$0.1154 per task**. Compared with GPT-5.2, that appears attractive: 75.6% lower estimated inference cost and 3.4 points more success. Compared with MiniMax alone, however, it adds only two resolved issues while costing approximately **57.4% more**. The quality-difference interval is −0.8 to +1.6 points, while the cost-ratio interval is 1.398 to 1.762. These

additional paired comparisons are explicitly labelled exploratory and conditional on the fitted policies. This operating point is not declared a winner after searching the grid. The whole grid and comparisons with the inexpensive standalone model are retained. Attributing all of the difference versus an expensive reference to intelligent routing would be misleading.

The recorded ten-model oracle resolves 87.8%, while the two-model oracle resolves 76.6%. These bounds suggest potential complementarity, but the oracles use the answers and realized costs. They do not demonstrate that an available router, personal agent or conversation policy can achieve those figures.

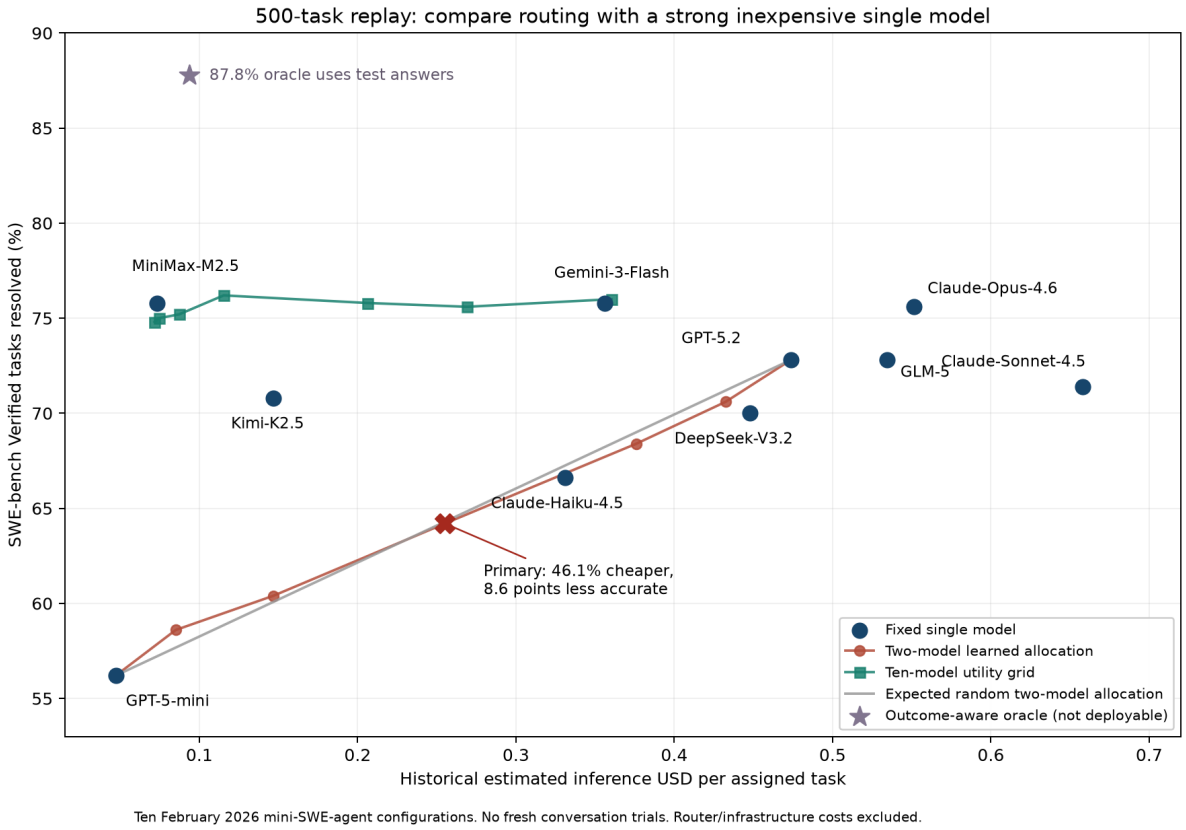


Figure 7.1: Historical SWE-bench Verified cost–quality operating points with standalone controls. Router points replay held-out model selections; the oracle uses unavailable test outcomes. Costs omit unobserved deployment expenses.

7.5 Statistical and economic limits

Intervals use 2,000 paired resamples and condition on the fitted cross-fold policies and the recorded outcomes; they do not refit the router inside every bootstrap sample. A repository-cluster sensitivity analysis uses only twelve clusters. Training and test folds can share repositories, so repository-unseen generalization is not established. One recorded attempt per model and task cannot estimate repeated-inference variance. Grid comparisons are exploratory and do not support a familywise claim from choosing their best point.

Upstream numerical costs are preserved rather than replaced by current prices. They are not independently audited invoices. Two unresolved Gemini entries

report zero cost despite one API call each; these values are not proof of free inference. Neither the primary policy nor the illustrated portfolio selects those entries. Their effect on other policies is recorded in the supplementary cost-source checks. Router fitting took roughly two CPU seconds in this run, but no electricity, machine allocation or test-execution dollar rate was measured. Total operational cost and Codex subscription-credit savings remain unknown. No new model-inference purchase was needed for this replay.

The implications for the conversational study are concrete. First, retain a strong low-cost standalone model in the comparison. Second, ask whether runtime evidence and conversation improve the weak pre-task selection result. Third, measure all controller, expert, verification and failed-attempt usage before claiming savings. The replay supplies a reproducible benchmark finding and better controls; the causal bidirectional-conversation experiment still needs fresh metered execution.

Chapter 8

Discussion and limits

The literature makes the central hypothesis plausible without making it new or settled. EdgeWise reports substantial cloud-API savings with small changes in software-task performance under particular conditions, but its accounting excludes the local SLM. Router-R1 and related work already make the router an active participant that reasons across model responses. The present study must therefore establish its value through reproducible comparisons, complete cost measurement and a precise intervention, rather than the assertion that models have never conversed before.

The proposed distinction is continuing expert dialogue: an expert can ask for missing evidence, challenge an interpretation and revise a proposal while the small controller continues working. That may prevent context omissions and uncritical acceptance. It may also waste time, encourage circular conversation or amplify a shared mistake. Compare it directly with one-way assistance and reset expert sessions under equal budgets. A bidirectional API alone is not a scientific contribution; the empirical finding, including a negative result, is the contribution.

The complete SWE-bench Verified replay sharpens this requirement. The primary pre-task router saves estimated inference dollars but loses too much quality, and a strong inexpensive standalone model undercuts the apparent advantage of several portfolio operating points. A conversational agent must therefore beat credible cheap standalone alternatives, not merely reduce calls to a costly reference. The replay is a standard-benchmark result, while its historical single-attempt data and unmeasured deployment expenses restrict its claims.

The pilot’s lack of optional consultations is a useful design lesson. Easy tasks can show that a controller avoids unnecessary expert work, but cannot evaluate its capacity to obtain help. The next development sample should span observed difficulty and failure modes before the final test is frozen. It must not select final tasks merely because they make conversation look useful. A registered development-stratified sampling rule, followed by an untouched test sample, can ensure both easy and difficult assignments without selecting on final-treatment outcomes.

The artifact-policy problem also matters. In a product, adding a good test to an existing file is usually desirable. In a controlled repair benchmark, altering the tests used for evaluation can invalidate success. The next protocol should make that distinction explicit: immutable evaluator tests are outside the worker, while permitted public-test additions are reviewed or applied under a declared patch

policy. The current frozen results remain intact. Reinterpreting them as proof that conversational agents cannot follow constraints would be unwarranted given the prompt ambiguity and tiny sample.

Personalization and long-term learning remain optional, separable questions. Editable memory has practical value as a user interface, but it does not automatically improve task success. Existing developer-skill research motivates generic and shuffled-user controls. RL can improve decisions without providing an economical training path at small scale. Training cost, privacy boundaries, feedback reliability and retained local capability must be measured. The current code uses no model-weight update, and the live Codex experiment has no access to the hosted models' weights.

More agents can supply complementary expertise, but also introduce duplicate work and harder credit assignment. The minimal dyadic design should establish when conversation helps before a many-to-many experiment claims emergent roles or self-improvement. Existing graph and multi-agent learning frameworks should be reused for that extension. The long-term ambition remains affordable, user-controlled AI; that social objective is not demonstrated by a four-task hosted-model pilot.

Chapter 9

Reproducibility and next execution

The repository contains the full protocol and adapted benchmark provenance, separate task workspaces, immutable grader source, regression reports, submitted patches, nullable-cost records, dialogue transcript and analysis code. It also contains a tested restore command that verifies downloaded archive hashes and replays all buggy/fixed controls before creating new worker copies. It refuses to overwrite existing destinations. The original source and evaluator trees are checked against their manifest before grading.

From a prepared research environment, the recorded analysis can be reproduced without any model calls:

```
python scripts/analyze_codex_pilot.py --output-dir results/my-pilot-analysis
python -m pytest -q
```

On a fresh compatible workspace, restore the historical benchmark fixtures:

```
python scripts/restore_codex_pilot.py --install-env
python scripts/restore_codex_pilot.py --verify-only
```

The analysis command requires the research dependencies in `requirements-research.lock`. Restore uses its separately pinned CPython 3.8.20 environment and legacy test dependencies, and downloads the exact registered public archives. The study is deliberately an adapted BugsInPy subset; the restore process does not claim to recreate every original benchmark environment. Do not execute new models in the recorded solved worker copies.

For a normal machine with a writable, authenticated Codex installation, the reusable adapter accepts a task manifest and a new output directory:

```
python -m ttgl.personal --task task.json --condition personal \
  --small-model gpt-6-luna --large-model gpt-6.1-sol \
  --max-expert-calls 2 --timeout-seconds 240 \
  --output-dir artifacts/new-conversation
```

The runbook documents the exact supported arguments, structured responses, resumed threads, failure disposition and grading boundary. Completion means the controller finished; it does not automatically mean the issue was resolved. A unit-tested fake backend verifies the control flow without pretending to be an LLM. The installed standalone CLI’s read-only-state failure in the present managed session

remains a known runtime limitation. The actual live trials used the collaboration tool instead and do not establish CLI service readiness.

The next performance experiment requires a larger frozen task sample, strong worker/evaluator isolation, unambiguous artifact rules, a native one-way assistance comparator and observable billing. It can use existing hosted Codex agents if their usage can be recorded, or compatible open models through an existing serving stack. A faithful reproduction of prior large-scale training requires additional resources; it is not silently charged to the existing US$100 Runpod allocation. No new credential is needed to reproduce the recorded analysis. Credentials and connectivity are still required for future paid GPU or provider runs.

The new `scripts/run_swe_bench.py` bridge implements six frozen conditions, mandatory native model-and-metering preflight, clean source checkouts, official prediction export and grade import. One-way proposals and reset-expert conversations are now software-tested arms. `scripts/collect_codex_usage.py` uses the official app-server's per-thread estimate route without new inference. The handover specifies the suitable writable host, official evaluator controls, worker dependency/isolation prerequisites, reproduction commands and pending work. Source-code readiness is distinct from successful live metering or a completed causal comparison.

Fastest Jira and Confluence synchronization remain unavailable in the current tool set. Local task records and an import CSV preserve progress; they are not remote issue keys or evidence of publication. The intended Confluence destination remains the FASTEST space at fastestswarm.atlassian.net.

Chapter 10

Conclusion

Small-model-led collaboration is established prior art, including learned delegation for software engineering. The defensible hypothesis is whether continuing, bounded conversation achieves materially lower **total** cost while retaining a prespecified level of task success, beyond single-model execution, initial routing and one-way assistance. Personal memory and learned skills can be tested as additional interventions.

The present work implements and tests the orchestration and measurement code, executes a four-condition historical-bug pilot, demonstrates one live two-round clarification exchange, and analyzes all 500 SWE-bench Verified tasks across ten published model runs. The primary replay router reduces estimated inference cost by 46.1% but loses 8.6 quality points; it fails the joint target. Portfolio results also show why an inexpensive strong standalone model is essential as a control. These are useful empirical findings without establishing live conversational savings or performance noninferiority. The next comparisons test that remaining causal claim with observable subscription or inference usage.

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